Curriculum Vitae **Riccardo Graziani**

PhD Candidate in Economics, VIVES Research Centre, KU Leuven
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Education

2023 – 2027 (Planned) **PhD Candidate in Economics**, KU Leuven (VIVES Research Centre)
Promotor: Prof. Dr. Joep Konings
Placement officer: Prof. Dr. Edoardo Ciscato

2022 **Master of Science in Economics** (Research Advanced Master), UCLouvain
Joint degree with Bocconi University

2022 **Master of Science in Economics and Social Sciences**, Bocconi University

2019 **Bachelor of Science in Economics and Social Sciences**, Bocconi University

References

Joep Konings
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Jakob Vanschoonbeek
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Working Papers

Who Speaks for the People? Electoral Reforms, Parliamentary Speech, and Legislative Behaviour in Belgium, 1880–1912 (JMP)

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Presented at the 'Text-as-data' in Economics Workshop, University of Bath (July 2026), and at DiPaDA 2026 (Digital Parliamentary Data in Action), University of Ljubljana (September 2026).

Abstract: Does extending the franchise change what a parliament attends to, and if so, does it work by changing the behaviour of the politicians already in office or by changing who holds office? We study this question in Belgium, which introduced plural male suffrage in 1894 and proportional representation in 1900, using a new dataset that links the plenary interventions of both chambers of parliament between 1880 and 1912 to the speaker's party and constituency, and to the bills that members introduced. The share of each intervention devoted to labour and social policy is measured by a transformer classifier trained for this corpus and validated against blind human coding. Because its eligibility census prevented working-class candidates from entering the Senate, the difference between the two chambers identifies the Chamber's differential response to electoral exposure, net of shocks common to both chambers, such as the strikes and unrest that produced the reforms. After enfranchisement, the Chamber's attention to the social question rose by 4.5 percentage points relative to the Senate's, on a base of 7.9, everywhere in the country and mainly among sitting deputies. Proportional representation produced no aggregate shift but a large effect in the coalfields, where it reopened seats the majoritarian rule had handed to the socialists. It was driven by the entry of new members. Social bills deposited by Catholic and Liberal members rose after 1894, mostly among Catholics, and again after 1900, among Liberals. Enfranchisement thus raised attention to the social question across the country, while proportional representation restored it in the coalfields through the members it elected. Which channel operated was set by the part of the electoral system each reform changed.

Partisanship in Belgian Parliamentary Speech: Evidence from the Chamber of Representatives, 1831–2025

Abstract: What can nearly two centuries of parliamentary debate tell us about divisions between Belgian parties? We study speeches in the Chamber of Representatives from 1831 to 2025, using the measure of Gentzkow et al. (2019). It asks how accurately a listener could identify a speaker's party from a single phrase. It measures differences in wording, not distances between policy positions. We remove routine parliamentary formulas and other phrases with little political content. Catholic and non-Catholic parties use similar language under census suffrage but become easier to distinguish after the Socialists enter parliament in 1894. Religious partisanship is modest for much of the twentieth century and never exceeds its random-label benchmark after the early 1990s. Contrary to what the conflicts over the monarchy and schools might suggest, the 1950s are not an exceptional

decade once procedural language is removed. The left is most distinct from other parties in 1898–1940 and again in 2024–2025, after several decades of relatively similar wording. Government and opposition are most distinct between the wars, but their language also differs in more than half the periods since 1995. Even at the peaks of these three series, a projection from the estimated model gives a listener only a 0.63–0.66 probability of classifying a speaker correctly after one minute, below the corresponding peaks in the United States and Finland. A narrower left–right comparison peaks in 1904–1932; the right becomes more distinct from the remaining parties after the 1970s, especially in 2024–2025. Since 1979, parties in opposition together have used more similar language. Before the national parties split, Flemish and Walloon members differed chiefly in their regional interests, without a growing gap in wording; members of the same party divided in roll calls mainly over language legislation. Event studies find that coalition partners align their votes as soon as they enter government, with little corresponding change in policy-related wording. After elections, the record shows more interruptions, approval and laughter for about three months. Like studies of the United States, Finland and Norway, we find a recent increase in some forms of partisanship, although the pattern depends on which parties are compared.

One Reform Divided the Elite, the Other Replaced It: Electoral Reform and Parliamentary Speech in the Belgian Belle Époque, 1880–1912

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Abstract: Did electoral reform change how Belgium's governing parties spoke to one another? We study two reforms: plural male suffrage, first applied in 1894, and proportional representation, introduced in 1900. The first changed who could vote; the second changed how votes translated into seats. Using 665,658 plenary interventions from both parliamentary houses, we measure Catholic–Liberal rhetorical polarization with the leave-out partisanship estimator of Gentzkow et al. (2019). We compare the Chamber with the Senate. Both faced the new electorate, but restrictive rules for Senate candidates limited the entry of socialists and reduced senators' exposure to electoral competition. After 1894, Catholic–Liberal distinctiveness rose by 0.0095 more in the Chamber than in the Senate, and by 0.0094 within the same politicians. The break occurs at the reform and is the largest among fourteen feasible cutoff dates. The increase lasts until 1900, is driven mainly by differences in how the parties spoke about the same subjects, and is strongest on labour and social policy. Catholic incumbents changed their language; among Liberals, the more distinctive speakers were chiefly the newly elected members. The 1900 reform presents a different identification problem. The election renewed both houses, and the Senate became more distinctive while the Chamber's score fell. We therefore cannot isolate the reform's effect on rhetorical polarization. We can, however, document substantial turnover: roughly half of the Senate's speaking members and three in ten Chamber members were new, while Catholic deputies returned to the coal districts from which majority rule had largely excluded them. The evidence distinguishes a reform that changed the speech of sitting politicians from one that clearly changed parliamentary representation, without claiming to identify the second reform's effect on speech.

Anti-Revolutionary Roads? The Political Effects of Belgium's Workmen's Trains

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Abstract: Between 1885 and 1910 Belgium built one of the world's densest light rail networks, partly as an instrument of political containment: the governing Catholic and Liberal parties hoped that letting workers reach city jobs while living in the countryside would shield them from the rising socialist movement, while the socialists hoped the same connectivity would carry their ideas into the hinterland. Using newly assembled archival data on the network, demography, commuting, and local elections, we develop a quantitative spatial political economy model of location, commuting, and political choices to adjudicate between the two views. Because the political effect runs partly through the endogenous reallocation of the electorate, we identify it from the unexpected component of light-rail-induced gains in job market access and show that the network moved location and commuting alone, leaving wages and rents unchanged. It modestly tempered urbanisation, lowering agglomeration populations by up to two percent, yet raised socialist vote shares where access improved most. Aggregated through the D'Hondt seat allocation rule, the network accounts for three parliamentary seats that passed to the left rather than the Catholics, slimming the governing majority from a counterfactual thirteen seats to seven. The incumbents' counter-revolutionary instrument, in short, modestly hastened the rise it was built to forestall.

Data Papers

The Belgian Chamber Debates Dataset: Speeches, Roll-Call Votes and Member Biographies, 1831–2025

Abstract: In this Data Descriptor, we introduce a dataset on the plenary speeches of the Belgian Chamber of Representatives and the background characteristics of the members who speak in it. The database includes all plenary speeches from the first sitting of the Chamber, in 1831, to the end of 2025, linked to the members and ministers who delivered them, together with the roll-call votes cast in the same sittings and a table of the bills and

other legislative files that came before the Chamber, with their subject keywords, to which the roll calls are linked. These data have been used in previous studies to analyze how plural voting and proportional representation changed what the Chamber talked about and how far apart its parties spoke. The long time period, from census suffrage to the federal state, makes it possible to study how historical changes are reflected in parliamentary speeches.

Research Experience

2019 – 2023 **Research Assistant**, Harvard Business School
for James M. Snyder and Marco Tabellini
- Python and Stata pipelines for large-scale historical data construction, using OCR and web scraping
- Unsupervised learning and sentiment analysis on large collections of political texts

2020 – 2023 **Research Assistant**, University of Rome Tor Vergata
for Stefano Gagliarducci
- Electoral and administrative data to study the impact of COVID-19 policies on electoral outcomes in Italy
- Gravity models estimated with high-dimensional fixed-effects regressions

Research Interest

PRIMARY	Political Economy, Economic History, Urban Economics
SECONDARY	Text as Data, Democratization and Representation, Political Polarization, Transport Networks

Technical and Language Skills

Programming	Python, Stata, R, C++, Matlab
Methods	Causal inference (difference-in-differences, instrumental variables), panel data, gravity models; machine learning, natural language processing, text classification; web scraping and OCR
Software	LaTeX, ArcGIS, ABBYY FineReader
Languages	Italian (Native), English (Fluent), French (Intermediate), Spanish (Intermediate)

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